Contextro: Token-Efficient Repository Discovery for MCP-Based Coding Workflows

Japneet Kalkat

Distillation Labs

japneet@distillation.ai

ABSTRACT

Repository discovery is a major source of token overhead in MCP-based coding workflows. This report evaluates Contextro, a proprietary local code-intelligence server for repository search, symbol navigation, structural analysis, and persistent memory, using a 60-task paired study on an 8,496-file production TypeScript monorepo. Relative to a bounded grep-based pipeline with repository-wide grep plus up to five file reads, the Contextro pipeline reduced total token consumption from 328,272 to 14,407, reduced median latency from 448.35 ms to 5.21 ms, and eliminated file reads. On the directly comparable 39-task subset, token consumption fell to 6,638, a 98.0% reduction; across 100 deterministic bootstrap subsets, reduction remained between 97.24% and 98.48%. Supplemental public verification now includes reruns on the open `src/` tree, a 39-task stronger-baseline rerun on a 1,179-file public proxy repository, and an 8-task deterministic edit-correctness benchmark. These results bound discovery efficiency and scripted edit correctness rather than full autonomous coding quality.

Keywords: Model Context Protocol, repository discovery, code intelligence, semantic retrieval, structural search, technical evaluation

1. Introduction

Repository discovery remains a costly phase in MCP-based coding workflows. Before a client can act on the correct symbol, file, or interface, it typically executes multiple broad searches, opens several files, and accumulates context that is only partially relevant to the task. In the paired study reported here, a representative grep-based workflow consumed 5,524 tokens and took 1.11 s, whereas the corresponding indexed `find_symbol` call returned in 5.66 ms with 65 tokens.

Contextro addresses this inefficiency by replacing file-by-file exploration with structured repository access. It exposes repository search, symbol navigation, relationship tracing, impact analysis, structural search, history lookup, and persistent memory through a local MCP server. The operating premise is straightforward: when discovery tasks can be answered directly, the client does not need to spend context budget reconstructing repository structure from raw files.

This report makes four bounded claims. First, a local code-intelligence layer can materially reduce the token cost of repository discovery. Second, the resulting interface can deliver low latency on a production-scale repository for common lookup tasks. Third, the effect remains visible under stricter analysis that separates directly comparable discovery tasks from MCP-native capabilities with no lexical analogue. Fourth, public supplementary artifacts can expose stronger local-tool baselines, exact MCP tool schemas, and deterministic edit-correctness checks without redistributing the private study corpus.

2. Related Work

This work sits within a broader literature on contextual retrieval, hybrid search, and prompt-budget management. Prior work from Anthropic, NVIDIA, Liu et al., and OpenAI argues that retrieval systems perform best when they combine multiple signals, rank relevant evidence near the top of the context window, and avoid transmitting unnecessary text. The present report applies that general logic to repository discovery, where the cost of locating the right code often dominates the cost of reasoning over it.

3. System Design

Contextro operates as a local MCP service positioned between the coding client and the repository. Rather than requiring exploratory file reads, it returns structured answers to discovery questions, including identifiers, locations, relationships, and compact supporting excerpts. The objective is to shift discovery from file traversal toward targeted retrieval.

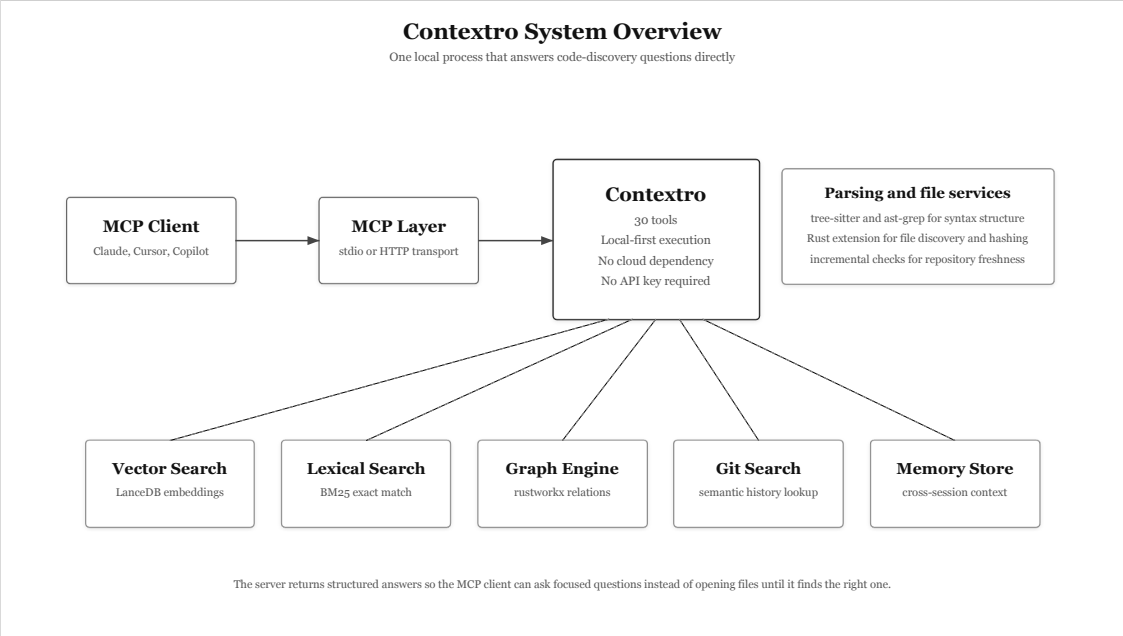

Figure 1. System overview. Contextro exposes a unified local interface for repository search, structural analysis, history lookup, and memory.

3.1. System Components

Table 1. Capability map.

Capability	Representative tools	Returned information
Search by meaning	`search`	Exact snippet, file, and line
Find a symbol	`find_symbol`	Definition location and caller count
Trace relationships	`find_callers`, `find_callees`, `explain`	Callers, callees, and local context
Assess blast radius	`impact`	Transitive impact set
Search structure	`code(pattern_search, ...)`	AST-level matches
Analyze reachability	`dead_code`, `circular_dependencies`	Structural analysis results
Search history	`commit_search`	Semantically relevant commits
Persist context	`remember`, `recall`	Durable memory across sessions

3.2. Retrieval and Response Design

The retrieval layer combines semantic, lexical, and structural signals. Semantic retrieval supports concept-level matching, lexical retrieval supports exact identifiers and strings, and graph-based traversal supports questions about callers, callees, and impact. Returned material is filtered and abbreviated so that the interface favors direct answers over large context transfers.

The implementation is local and single-process. It integrates vector indexing, lexical retrieval, structural analysis, syntax-aware search, history lookup, and memory in one service boundary. That integration matters operationally because it eliminates the need to orchestrate several external systems during interactive discovery.

4. Methodology

The evaluation uses a paired two-condition design on a single production repository. Each task is executed once with a bounded grep-based discovery workflow and once with the Contextro pipeline. The full task inventory contains 60 tasks across 16 categories. Among these, 39 tasks have direct file-centric analogues and therefore support strict paired comparison; the remaining 21 tasks represent MCP-native capabilities with no meaningful file-centric baseline.

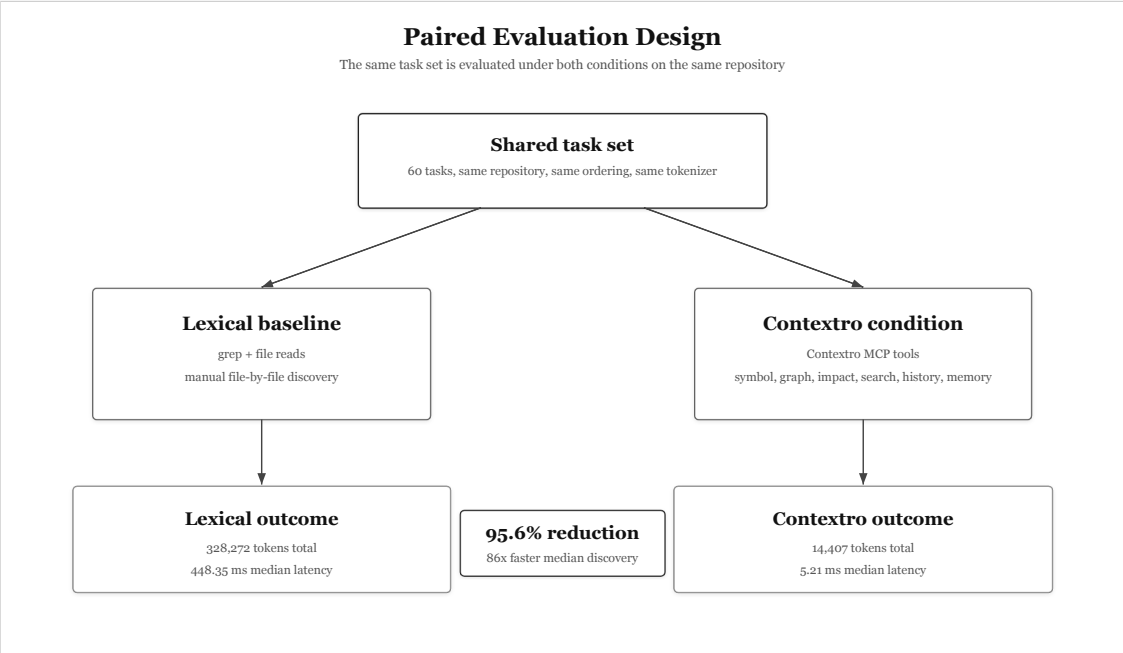

Figure 2. Study design. The same task set is evaluated under both conditions on the same repository, preserving a paired comparison.

4.1. Study Design

The primary comparison pairs a bounded grep-based pipeline with the Contextro pipeline. For each directly comparable task, the grep-based pipeline records repository-wide grep output and the contents of up to five matching files in the token estimate. The Contextro pipeline executes one MCP tool call against a pre-indexed repository state. Tasks without a meaningful file-centric analogue are retained in the full inventory as MCP-native capabilities, but they are excluded from the directly comparable subset and from the bootstrap robustness analysis. Both study arms are scripted pipelines rather than autonomous LLM agents.

This design isolates discovery cost rather than downstream coding quality. It compares a file-centric grep-based pipeline with a structured retrieval interface under a fixed task inventory, shared repository, and common token accounting rule.

4.2. Repository Under Test

Table 2. Repository under test.

Property	Value
Repository	Private production TypeScript monorepo
Indexed files	8,496 files in the private production monorepo
Languages	TypeScript and JavaScript
Task inventory	60 tasks across 16 categories

Property	Value
Directly comparable subset	39 tasks across 8 categories
MCP-native tasks	21 tasks without meaningful file-centric analogues
Indexing observation	21.1 s full indexing time in the fresh rerun
Verification host	Apple M4, 16 GB RAM, macOS 26.4.1, Python 3.12.13

4.3. Metrics and Reporting

Table 3. Metrics and reporting.

Measurement	Definition	Artifact
Token estimate	Common tokenizer applied to baseline outputs and Contextro responses	Aggregate study summary and rerun summary
Latency	Wall-clock milliseconds measured around each task invocation	Aggregate study summary and rerun summary
Tool calls and files read	Count of baseline grep/read steps versus one MCP tool call	Aggregate study summary and rerun summary
Comparable subset	All tasks with a direct file-centric analogue	Comparable-task catalog and subset robustness analysis
Robustness analysis	100 bootstrap task subsets of size 39 with replacement	Subset robustness analysis
Open benchmark verification	Public reruns on the open `src/` tree for token and retrieval checks	Public benchmark artifacts
Public stronger-baseline rerun	39-task public proxy benchmark comparing a stronger local-tools pipeline (`git grep`, regex search, file reads, `git log`) with Contextro	Public proxy benchmark artifacts
Deterministic edit correctness	8 discovery-plus-edit tasks scored by exact replacement checks and post-edit syntax validation	Edit correctness benchmark artifact
Tool API schema export	Machine-readable input/output schemas with example requests and responses for 30 tools	Schema export artifact

The study is deterministic rather than stochastic in the usual machine-learning sense, so reporting emphasizes medians, ranges, and subset robustness rather than significance testing. The bootstrap analysis is used as a sensitivity check on task composition, not as a population-level inference over repositories.

Supplemental public methodology addresses three credibility gaps left by the private paired study. A tracked 1,179-file public proxy repository with 39 comparable discovery tasks provides a redistributable rerun target. That proxy corpus is Python-based, so the edit benchmark uses `py_compile` as its syntax-validity check. A stronger local-tools pipeline built from `git grep`, regex search, direct file reads, and `git log` offers a stricter public control than grep alone. An additional 8-task deterministic edit benchmark requires correct target-file selection, exact rewrite application, and post-edit `py_compile` syntax-validity checks. Exact JSON request/response schemas and example payloads for 30 tools are exported as a machine-readable artifact.

5. Results

5.1. Headline Outcomes

Across the full 60-task inventory, total token consumption fell from 328,272 in the bounded grep-based pipeline to 14,407 in the Contextro pipeline. Mean tokens per task fell from 5,471.2 to 240.1, median latency fell from 448.35 ms to 5.21 ms, and mean files read fell from 2.5 per task to 0. **The primary control is a bounded grep-based pipeline, not an LSP-backed or autonomous coding baseline. The reported gains therefore characterize discovery efficiency rather than universal coding quality.**

The stricter comparison is the 39-task subset with direct file-centric analogues. On that subset, token use fell to 6,638, a 98.0% reduction, while median latency fell from 498.89 ms to 4.89 ms and mean tool calls fell from 4.9 to 1.0. The gap between the 60-task and 39-task summaries reflects the presence of 21 MCP-native tasks that expose analysis surfaces absent from the grep-based pipeline.

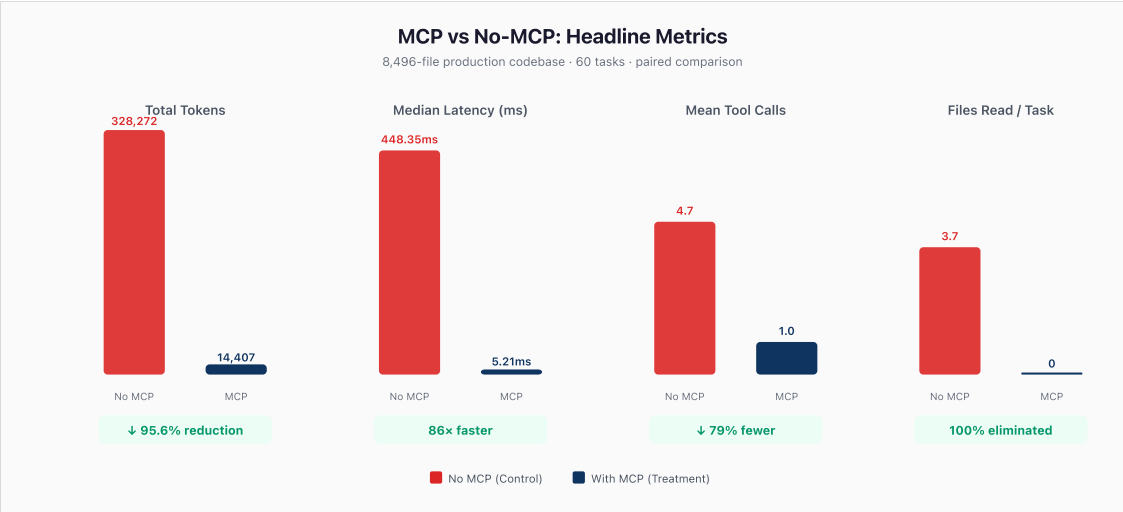

Figure 3. Headline outcomes from the paired study. The figure summarizes the full task inventory; the stricter directly comparable subset is reported separately in Table 4.

Table 4. Headline outcomes.

Analysis set	Tasks	MCP-native tasks	Lexical tokens	Contextro tokens	Token result	Median latency
Full task inventory	60	21	328,272	14,407	95.6% reduction	448.35 ms → 5.21 ms
Directly comparable subset	39	0	328,272	6,638	98.0% reduction	498.89 ms → 4.89 ms
100 bootstrap subsets	100 × 39	0	—	—	median 97.87% 97.24%-98.48%	lexical 458.28-525.76 ms Contextro 2.15-7.00 ms

No bootstrap subset fell below 97.24% token reduction. The effect therefore remains stable across many task mixtures drawn from the directly comparable subset.

5.2. Results by Category

Table 5 reports the eight categories with direct file-centric analogues. Semantic search and symbol discovery show the largest reductions at 98.8%. Caller tracing, impact analysis, code understanding, git history search, and the comparable portion of the `code` tool remain above 96%.

Tail latency is concentrated in a small number of heavier operations. The `focus` category is bimodal because one request returns in 4.81 ms while another deep file-context request takes 7.01 s. The comparable `code` category also contains a repository-wide `pattern_search` outlier at 11.22 s.

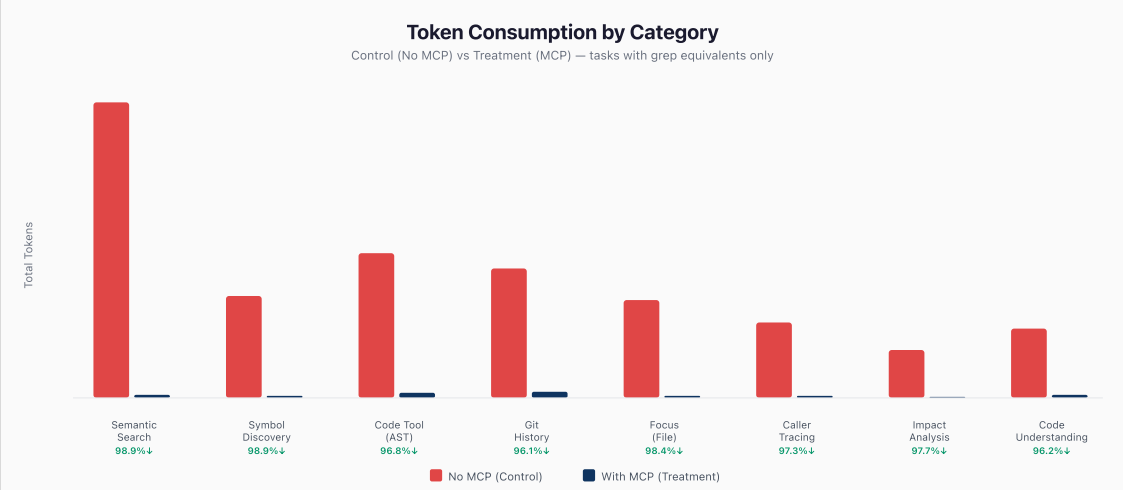

Figure 4. Results by task category. The visualization focuses on discovery categories with direct file-centric analogues.

Table 5. Results by category.

Category	Comparable tasks	Lexical tokens	Contextro tokens	Reduction	Contextro latency
Semantic search	8	96,366	1,199	98.8%	131.53 ms median 95.19-138.31 ms
Symbol discovery	8	34,481	413	98.8%	1.81 ms median 1.37-9.13 ms
Caller/callee tracing	6	25,915	730	97.2%	1.46 ms median 0.92-4.89 ms
Impact analysis	4	16,225	377	97.7%	0.93 ms median 0.90-3.68 ms
Code understanding	6	23,526	944	96.0%	6.68 ms median 6.22-8.26 ms
Git history search	2	46,106	1,117	97.6%	6.51 ms median 5.21-7.80 ms
Code tool (comparable slice)	3	51,459	1,318	97.4%	1.92 ms median 0.97 ms-11.22 s
Focus / file context	2	34,194	540	98.4%	3.51 s median 4.81 ms-7.01 s

5.3. Tool Latency

Most lookup and graph operations remain in the low-millisecond range. The long tail is composed of a small number of deliberately heavier analyses rather than broad slowness. In the fresh rerun, `focus_01` took 7.01 s and repository-wide `code(pattern_search, ...)` took 11.22 s; both are preserved explicitly in Appendix C rather than absorbed into category means.

Table 6. Representative tool latencies.

Tool	Fresh rerun latency	Role
`health`	0.88 ms	Server status
`status`	1.47 ms	Server status
`find_callers`	1.97 ms median	Graph lookup
`find_symbol`	1.81 ms median	Symbol lookup
`impact`	0.93 ms median	Blast radius analysis
`explain`	6.68 ms median	Local understanding
`commit_search`	6.51 ms median	History search
`overview`	93.24 ms	Project summary
`search`	131.53 ms median	Hybrid retrieval
`architecture`	436.75 ms	Deep structural summary
`dead_code`	1,307.18 ms	Reachability analysis
`code(pattern_search, ...)`	11.22 s	Repository-wide AST search outlier

5.4. Public Verification and Supplemental Benchmarks

Public artifact reruns now span three layers: the original open-`src/` verification checks, a larger 1,179-file public proxy repository benchmark with a stronger local-tools pipeline, and a deterministic discovery-plus-edit correctness benchmark. Together these materials do not replace the private monorepo evaluation, but they provide external evidence for stronger controls, redistributable tasks, and exact tool contracts.

Table 7. Public verification and supplemental methodology artifacts.

Artifact	Measurement	Result	Source
Public token rerun	16-call public workflow benchmark	1,286 total output tokens; 16 calls; 7.5% token reduction	Public benchmark artifact
Public retrieval rerun	20 query retrieval benchmark on `src/`	Hybrid MRR 1.0, Recall@1 1.0, Recall@5 1.0, 169.2 avg tokens	Public benchmark artifact
Public proxy stronger baseline	39 discovery tasks on a 1,179-file redistributable proxy repository	39/39 success in both pipelines; 343.59 to 106.18 mean tokens/task (-69.1%); 36.82 ms to 8.89 ms mean latency	`public-proxy-strong-baseline.json`
Deterministic edit correctness	8 discovery-plus-edit tasks with exact rewrite and syntax checks	8/8 success in both pipelines; 12.69 ms to 6.37 ms mean latency; 194.38 vs 326.0 mean tokens/task	`edit-correctness-benchmark.json`
Tool API schema export	Machine-readable contracts for public MCP interfaces	30 tool schemas with annotations plus example request/response payloads	`contextro-tool-api-schemas.json`

The proxy rerun is intentionally harder than the original open-`src/` checks. It uses a larger redistributable repository and a stronger local-tools pipeline composed of `git grep`, regex search, direct file reads, and `git log`. Contextro still preserved 39/39 task success while reducing mean tokens by 69.1%, reducing mean latency from 36.82 ms to 8.89 ms, and reducing mean tool calls from 2.95 to 1.0.

The deterministic edit benchmark closes part of the end-to-end gap by requiring correct target discovery, exact rewrite application, and post-edit syntax validity. Both pipelines achieved 8/8 successful edits. On these narrowly scripted constant-update tasks, Contextro was faster but returned larger structured payloads, so the result should be read as correctness and orchestration evidence rather than as a new token-efficiency headline.

6. Discussion

The most important interpretive point is that the result becomes stronger, not weaker, under the stricter directly comparable subset. The full 60-task inventory shows a 95.6% token reduction, while the 39-task subset shows a 98.0% reduction because it excludes MCP-native capabilities that have no direct file-centric baseline. This separation clarifies the distinction between replacing file-centric discovery and adding entirely new analysis surfaces.

The bootstrap robustness analysis strengthens that interpretation. Across 100 deterministic task subsets, reduction never fell below 97.24% and the median remained 97.87%. These values do not establish universal generalization across repositories, but they do indicate that the result is not driven by a small number of unusually favorable tasks.

Latency should be interpreted similarly. Common lookup operations are effectively instantaneous, while a few repository-wide analyses remain expensive. The practical result is not uniform sub-10 ms performance; it is that routine discovery operations remain fast while deeper structural queries continue to return structured answers at substantially lower token cost than exploratory file reads.

The supplemental public artifacts narrow two obvious credibility gaps. First, the 1,179-file proxy repository replaces the tiny open-tree rerun with a redistributable codebase large enough to exercise symbol search, graph traversal, regex search, and seeded git-history tasks under a stronger local-tools pipeline. Second, the deterministic edit benchmark shows that the retrieved target can be carried through exact code changes and syntax validation. Neither supplement transforms the paper into a universal agent benchmark, but both make the publication claims easier to audit externally.

7. Limitations

The findings in this report are bounded. They describe repository discovery efficiency under a paired task protocol, not general-purpose coding quality under all workflows or repositories.

Table 8. Study limitations.

Area	Issue	Status
Paired-study codebase availability	The original 8,496-file monorepo is private and cannot be redistributed with the paper	Mitigated by shipping the harness, sanitized task inventory, public proxy repository, rerun summaries, and public benchmark artifacts
Control baseline approximation	The main paired study uses a bounded grep-based pipeline rather than an LSP-backed or autonomous coding baseline	Partly mitigated by a supplemental public rerun against a stronger local-tools pipeline; claims remain limited to discovery efficiency rather than universal coding quality
Tail latency	`focus_01` and repository-wide `pattern_search` dominate the latency tail at 7.01 s and 11.22 s	Reported explicitly in Appendix C and excluded from any misleading latency simplification

Area	Issue	Status
Public proxy repository	The private paired-study corpus remains undistributable	Partly mitigated by shipping a 1,179-file public proxy repository with 39 comparable discovery tasks and seeded git history
End-to-end correctness	The primary paired study optimizes discovery cost (tokens, latency, file reads) rather than autonomous coding success	Partly mitigated by a deterministic 8-task edit benchmark with exact-rewrite and syntax-validation checks; still not a substitute for a full autonomous-agent evaluation
Tool API visibility	Printed tables cannot carry the full JSON contracts for every MCP tool	Mitigated by publishing machine-readable request/response schemas and example payloads for 30 tools
Next.js App Router reachability	`dead_code` flags live routes as unreachable	Known limitation
Duplicate symbol disambiguation	Multiple definitions with the same name can conflate callees	Under investigation
Complexity metrics	`maintainability_index` reports 0 for TypeScript	Not yet implemented for TS

The study still evaluates one production TypeScript monorepo and does not include an LSP-backed or autonomous-agent baseline on the private corpus. The supplemental artifacts narrow these gaps by adding a stronger local-tools proxy rerun, a public proxy repository, a deterministic edit benchmark, and a machine-readable tool-schema export, but the claims in this report should still be read as bounded claims about discovery performance and scripted edit correctness rather than universal agent quality.

8. Availability and Reproducibility

The public artifact package distinguishes between materials that can be rerun on public code and materials that remain conditional because the primary study corpus is private. It now includes sanitized task catalogs, aggregate study summaries, open-tree reruns, a redistributable 1,179-file public proxy repository, a stronger-baseline proxy benchmark, a deterministic edit benchmark, and a machine-readable tool-schema export. **Contextro is a proprietary product of Distillation Labs and is not distributed as open-source software.**

8.1. Artifact Package

Artifact class	Public contents
Task definitions	Sanitized machine-readable catalogs for the 60-task full inventory, the 39-task directly comparable subset, and the public proxy discovery/edit suites
Aggregate study outputs	Archived and fresh paired-study summaries, plus the 100-subset robustness analysis
Public proxy suite	Tracked 1,179-file redistributable proxy repository with seeded git-history benchmark setup
Public reruns	Token-efficiency and retrieval-quality reruns on the public `src/` tree, the 39-task stronger-baseline proxy benchmark, and the deterministic edit benchmark
Tool API contracts	Machine-readable request/response schemas and example payloads for 30 tools
Evaluation harness	Scripts required to reproduce public benchmarks and to rerun the paired study where an equivalent private repository is available

8.2. Rerunnable Commands (Public Benchmarks)

```
pip install -e .[dev]

python3.11 scripts/public_proxy_repo.py
python3.11 scripts/benchmark_public_proxy.py --proxy-repo docs/publication/public_proxy_repo --
output docs/publication/public-proxy-strong-baseline.json
python3.11 scripts/benchmark_end_to_end_correctness.py --output docs/publication/edit-correctness-
benchmark.json
python3.11 scripts/export_tool_api_schemas.py --output docs/publication/contextro-tool-api-
schemas.json
python3.11 scripts/benchmark_token_efficiency.py
python3.11 scripts/benchmark_retrieval_quality.py --path src --query-limit 20 --output
docs/publication/open-retrieval-quality.json

ruff check .
pytest -v -m "not slow"
```

8.3. Conditional Paired-Study Rerun

The full paired study requires access to the original private monorepo or to an adapted equivalent repository. The published catalogs preserve task counts, categories, and tool coverage without disclosing private repository identifiers. Where an equivalent repository is available locally, the rerun protocol is:

```
python scripts/experiment_platform.py --output-dir docs/publication --export-task-catalogs-only
python scripts/experiment_platform.py --codebase /path/to/private-monorepo --output-dir
/secure/local-output
python scripts/task_subset_robustness.py --results /secure/local-output/results.json --subsets 100
--output docs/publication/paired-study-subset-robustness.json
```

8.4. Verification Environment

The private paired-study reruns cited in this report were executed on Apple silicon hardware using macOS 26.4.1, an Apple M4 CPU, 16 GB RAM, and Python 3.12.13. The supplemental public proxy, edit-correctness, and schema-export artifacts were regenerated on the same hardware class under Python 3.11.15. The public benchmark harness supports Python 3.10-3.12.

9. Conclusion

Contextro demonstrates that a local code-intelligence layer can reduce the token and latency cost of repository discovery in MCP-based coding workflows. In the paired evaluation reported here, the full 60-task inventory reduced total tokens by 95.6%, while the stricter 39-task directly comparable subset reduced them by 98.0% and remained above 97.24% across 100 bootstrap task subsets. Supplemental public artifacts show that the direction of the effect survives a stronger local-tools proxy rerun and that the resulting discovery outputs can drive correct scripted code changes, although the paper still does not claim superiority on full autonomous coding benchmarks. The primary conclusion remains narrow but durable: structured repository access can materially outperform bounded file-centric discovery for repository search and navigation.

References

1. Anthropic. "Contextual Retrieval." 2024. https://www.anthropic.com/engineering/contextual-retrieval
2. Liu et al. "Lost in the Middle." 2023. https://arxiv.org/abs/2307.03172
3. NVIDIA. "RAG 101: Retrieval-Augmented Generation Questions Answered." 2023. https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/rag-101-retrieval-augmented-generation-questions-answered/

4. NVIDIA. "Finding the Best Chunking Strategy for Accurate AI Responses." 2025. https://developer.nvidia.com/blog/finding-the-best-chunking-strategy-for-accurate-ai-responses/
5. OpenAI. "Prompt Caching in the API." 2024. https://openai.com/index/api-prompt-caching/

Appendix A. Experiment Configuration

Appendix A summarizes the paired-study configuration at a high level. It is included to document study scope and reporting parameters without exposing implementation details beyond what is necessary for interpretation.

Parameter	Value
Total task inventory	60 tasks across 16 categories
Directly comparable subset	39 tasks with direct file-centric analogues
MCP-native tasks	21 tasks with no meaningful file-centric baseline
Token accounting	Common tokenizer applied to baseline outputs and Contextro responses
Primary control pipeline	Repository-wide grep plus bounded follow-up file inspection
Robustness procedure	100 bootstrap task subsets of size 39 with replacement
Verification host	macOS 26.4.1, Apple M4, 16 GB RAM, Python 3.12.13
Public supporting artifacts	Sanitized task catalogs, aggregate summaries, robustness outputs, and public benchmark reruns

Appendix B. MCP Tool API Contracts

This appendix summarizes the externally visible MCP tool contracts used by the evaluation. Parameter lists and response fields are described at the interface level. All tools return an MCP `ToolResult` whose `structured_content` field carries the JSON payload summarized below; errors are returned as `{"error": "…message…"}`. The exact machine-readable companion file `contextro-tool-api-schemas.json` publishes JSON Schema-compatible input and output definitions, annotations, and example request/response payloads for 30 tools.

B.1. Discovery and Navigation

`search(...)` returns ranked retrieval results with file locations, symbol labels, and compact code excerpts.

`find_symbol(...)` returns exact or fuzzy symbol matches, including definition metadata and local relationship counts.

`find_callers(...)` and `find_callees(...)` return direct relationship sets for the requested symbol.

`explain(...)` returns symbol metadata together with explanatory prose and supporting snippets.

`impact(...)` returns a transitive impact set summarizing affected symbols, files, and directories.

B.2. Project Intelligence

`overview()`, `architecture()`, `focus(...)`, and `restore()` return project- or file-level summaries intended to orient the client within the repository.

`analyze(...)`, `dead_code()`, `circular_dependencies()`, `test_coverage_map()`, and `audit()` return higher-level analysis summaries rather than direct retrieval results.

B.3. Git and History

`commit_search(...)` returns ranked commit matches for a query, while `commit_history(...)` returns chronological commit lists. `repo_status()` summarizes the multi-repository registry state.

B.4. Code Intelligence

`code(operation, ...)` dispatches syntax-aware operations such as symbol lookup, pattern search, and codebase overview generation. Output structure varies by operation but consistently returns result or match collections.

B.5. Memory and Session

`remember(...)`, `recall(...)`, and `forget(...)` manage persistent memory entries. `knowledge(...)`, `session_snapshot()`, and `compact(...)` manage broader session and knowledge state.

B.6. Server Utilities

`status()`, `health()`, and `index(...)` expose operational server state. `retrieve(...)` fetches sandboxed large responses by reference, and `introspect(...)` returns runtime tool schemas and settings.

Table 9. MCP tool API contracts summary.

Tool	Category	Primary inputs	Primary outputs
`search`	Discovery	query, limit, mode, language, symbol_type	total, results[symbol_name, score, filepath, li
`find_symbol`	Discovery	name, exact	n, f, l, t, callers, callees (single) / total, symbol
`find_callers`	Discovery	symbol_name	callers[] (single) / definitions[{definition, call
`find_callees`	Discovery	symbol_name	callees[]
`explain`	Discovery	symbol_name, verbosity	merged symbol fields, analysis, related_code
`impact`	Discovery	symbol_name, max_depth	total_impacted, impacted_symbols, impacted
`overview`	Intelligence	(none)	total_files, total_symbols, total_relationships
`architecture`	Intelligence	(none)	layers, entry_points, hub_symbols, top_class
`focus`	Intelligence	path, include_code	role, symbols, imports, nearby_tests, blast_ra
`restore`	Intelligence	(none)	project, entry_points, layers, risk_summary
`analyze`	Intelligence	path	complexity, code_smells, quality
`dead_code`	Intelligence	(none)	summary, unused_files, unused_symbols
`circular_dependencies`	Intelligence	(none)	summary, cycles
`test_coverage_map`	Intelligence	(none)	summary, uncovered_files, uncovered_symb
`audit`	Intelligence	(none)	summary, recommendations
`commit_search`	Git	query, limit, branch, author	total, results[hash, author, date, message, top
`commit_history`	Git	path, limit, since	total, branch, commits[hash, author, date, me
`repo_status`	Git	(none)	total_repos, total_files, repos, watcher
`code`	AST	operation, query/pattern/...	results or matches (shape varies by operation)
`remember`	Memory	content, memory_type, tags, ttl	id, status
`recall`	Memory	query, limit, memory_type, tags	total, memories[]
`forget`	Memory	memory_id, tags, memory_type	deleted_count
`session_snapshot`	Session	(none)	codebase, branch, head, vector_chunks, symb
`compact`	Session	content	archived, archive_ref, chars, hint
`status`	Server	(none)	codebase_path, indexed, graph{n,r,f}
`health`	Server	(none)	status, uptime_seconds, indexed, engines
`index`	Server	path, paths	status, message, path
`retrieve`	Server	ref_id, query	ref_id, content
`introspect`	Server	query, doc_path	tools, settings (full runtime schemas)

Table 9 is the print-friendly summary. The full schema artifact is included in the publication package so external readers can inspect exact parameter types, optional fields, and example payloads without relying on the proprietary server source.

Appendix C. Paired-Study Results by Tool Family

Table 10 reports aggregate token and latency measurements grouped by tool family. Rows marked *No* in the lexical-equivalent column represent MCP-native capabilities and are excluded from the directly comparable subset and bootstrap analyses discussed in Section 5.

Table 10. Paired-study results by tool family.

Tool family	Category	Lexical equivalent?	Lexical tokens	Contextro tokens	Contextro latency (ms)	Reduction
find_symbol ×8	Symbol discovery	Yes	34,481	413	1.37–9.13	98.8%
find_callers/find_callees ×6	Caller tracing	Yes	25,915	730	0.92–4.89	97.2%
search ×8	Semantic search	Yes	96,366	1,199	95.19–138.31	98.8%
explain ×6	Code understanding	Yes	23,526	944	6.22–8.26	96.0%
impact ×4	Impact analysis	Yes	16,225	377	0.90–3.68	97.7%
focus ×2	File context	Yes	34,194	540	4.81–7,009.60	98.4%
commit_search ×2	Git history	Yes	46,106	1,117	5.21–7.80	97.6%
code ×5 (3 comparable / 2 native)	AST operations	Mixed	51,459	1,627	0.97–11,222.49	96.8%
commit_history ×1	Git history	No	—	919	93.18	N/A
overview	Project structure	No	—	85	93.24	N/A
architecture	Project structure	No	—	893	436.75	N/A
analyze	Code quality	No	—	1,128	29.21	N/A
dead_code	Static analysis	No	—	933	1,307.18	N/A
circular_dependencies	Static analysis	No	—	545	0.77	N/A
test_coverage_map	Static analysis	No	—	555	11.16	N/A
audit	Full report	No	—	994	72.52	N/A
remember/recall/forget	Memory	No	—	161	4.04–13.35	N/A
session_snapshot/restore/compact	Session	No	—	984	0.86–53.54	N/A
status/health	Server ops	No	—	107	0.88–1.47	N/A
introspect	Self-documentation	No	—	46	0.31	N/A
repo_status	Multi-repo	No	—	102	1.40	N/A
knowledge (show)	Knowledge base	No	—	8	0.47	N/A